

Denver → Yellowstone — RV Road Trip

9–15 July 2026 | Mr Mark Williams, party of 4 | Road Bear Class C 29–31' | Booking CXF847765-1
Arrive DEN Thu 9 Jul 11:00 · depart DEN Wed 15 Jul 14:05 · pickup & drop-off: Road Bear, 6586 Brighton Blvd, Commerce City · +1 720-570-1100.

***This version:** cowboy gear on the way up, two Yellowstone bases (Fishing Bridge then Madison), the Cody Nite Rodeo on Sunday, and a relaxed three-leg drive home reaching the Fort Collins lake KOA early. Driving times every day.*

Route at a glance

Date	Overnight	Driving (approx.)	Highlights
Thu 9 Jul	Casper, WY	4h30 / 265 mi	Land, pickup, big shop, drive north
Fri 10 Jul	Fishing Bridge RV	~5h50 / 293 mi	Cowboy store , hot springs, into the park
Sat 11 Jul	Madison (geyser side)	~1h35 / 64 mi	Geysers, then a riverside base
Sun 12 Jul	Cody, WY	~3h30 / 130 mi	Canyon & Hayden, then rodeo 8 PM
Mon 13 Jul	Casper, WY	3h55 / 214 mi	Easy drive south (optional soak)
Tue 14 Jul	Fort Collins, CO	3h30 / 230 mi	Arrive early — enjoy the lake!
Wed 15 Jul	Fly home	1h00 / 50 mi	Drop by 10:30, fly 14:05

The drive home is now three short legs instead of one marathon — you reach the Fort Collins lake KOA by early afternoon on Tuesday. Total RV driving ~25 hours / ~1,280 mi of the 1,400 included.

Where you're staying

Night	RV park	Where & how to book
Thu 9 Jul	Casper KOA Journey	Bar Nunn, off I-25 — book direct , +1 307-577-1664
Fri 10 Jul	Fishing Bridge RV Park	Inside Yellowstone — Yellowstone NP Lodges, +1 307-344-7311
Sat 11 Jul	Madison Campground	Inside Yellowstone — Yellowstone NP Lodges (sells out first)
Sun 12 Jul	Parkway RV Campground	Cody, by Stampede Park — book direct , +1 307-527-5927
Mon 13 Jul	Casper KOA Journey	Bar Nunn, off I-25 — book direct , +1 307-577-1664
Tue 14 Jul	Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA	Fort Collins — book direct , +1 970-484-9880

Four nights outside the park you book yourself (Casper ×2, Cody, Fort Collins — all full hook-ups). The two Yellowstone nights (Fishing Bridge, then Madison) are booked through Yellowstone National Park Lodges — Madison sells out first, so grab it the instant your dates are bookable.

Book these now (priority order)

- **Road Bear pickup appointment** — call +1 720-570-1100 to lock your 9 Jul slot (1:00–4:00 PM window).

- **Fishing Bridge RV Park × 1 night** (Fri 10 Jul) — the only full-hookup site in the park, hard-sided rigs only. Yellowstone NP Lodges: +1 307-344-7311 / 866-439-7375. Combined length ~31 ft.
- **Madison Campground × 1 night** (Sat 11 Jul) — the **first Yellowstone campground to sell out each summer night**, so book it the instant your dates are bookable. Same line: +1 307-344-7311. Dry camping, dump station, 31 ft fine. **Most urgent.**
- **Parkway RV Campground, Cody × 1 night (Sun 12 Jul)** — closest park to Stampede Park (the rodeo), across from a Walmart. Book direct: +1 307-527-5927.
- **Cody Nite Rodeo × 4 (Sun 12 Jul, 8:00 PM, Stampede Park)** — codystampederoodeo.com (~\$25–79/seat) or at the gate; gates 7:00 PM.
- **Casper KOA Journey × 2 nights** (Thu 9 Jul AND Mon 13 Jul) — book direct, +1 307-577-1664 (pool, dog park, just off I-25).
- **Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA × 1** (Tue 14 Jul) — book direct, +1 970-484-9880.
- **Park entrance pass** — on Recreation.gov. \$35/vehicle (7 days), OR the \$250 Non-Resident Annual Pass if travelling as UK residents (covers all 4 + every park for a year). **Cowboy store:** Lou Taubert, Casper (Fri 10 Jul, opens 10:00) — no booking.

Day by day (with departure & arrival times)

Day 1 — Thu 9 July: Land Denver → Casper

Driving ~4h30 / 265 mi (after pickup & shop)

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Commerce City → Casper (I-25 N)	15:30	20:15	4h30*	265

11:00 Land at DEN. **11:45** bags, then Road Bear shuttle / Uber to the branch (~20 min) — luggage only, not the RV yet.

13:00 Pickup appointment, 6586 Brighton Blvd. Walkthrough 60–90 min, paperwork, deposit (balance \$4,085.03 due; \$300 already paid on the Amex).

~14:30 Big shop — Walmart Supercenter, 5990 Dahlia St (5 min from the branch): a week of water, food, snacks, coffee, sealed/zip bags for bear-safe storage, sunscreen, bug spray, torches.

15:30 North on I-25. ***~17:45** fuel & leg-stretch at Wheatland (~140 mi). Summer light to ~20:45.

~20:15 arrive Casper; cook in or grab dinner.

Fuel: Tank starts full. Splash-and-dash at Wheatland; top up in Casper.

Overnight: Casper KOA Journey (Bar Nunn), +1 307-577-1664

Day 2 — Fri 10 July: Casper → Yellowstone — cowboy gear & hot springs

Driving ~5h50 / 293 mi — the big scenic transit day

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Casper → Thermopolis	11:45	14:00	2h15	130
Thermopolis → Cody	15:30	17:10	1h40	84
Cody → Fishing Bridge	17:30	19:25	1h55	79

10:00 Lou Taubert Ranch Outfitters, 125 E 2nd St, Casper (opens 10:00) — six floors of Western wear; cowboy hats & boots for the family. ~1h30.

11:45 Depart Casper; Wind River Canyon en route (2,500-ft walls).

14:00 Thermopolis — lunch + a soak at Hot Springs State Park (free State Bath House, ~20-min soak). Wyoming Dinosaur Center next door for the kids.

15:30 Depart; quick fuel in Cody (~17:10), then the scenic Wapiti Valley and over Sylvan Pass (8,500 ft — steady).

~19:25 arrive Fishing Bridge (light until ~21:00). Full hookups, showers, laundry. Hard-sided rigs only here — store all food inside.

Fuel: FILL IN CODY before the park — last good-value fuel; in-park gas is pricier.

Overnight: Fishing Bridge RV Park (1 night)

Day 3 — Sat 11 July: Fishing Bridge → Madison — Geyser Country

Driving ~1h35 / 64 mi — an easy geyser day, ending on the river

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Fishing Bridge → West Thumb	09:00	09:20	0h20	21
West Thumb → Old Faithful	09:30	10:05	0h35	19
Old Faithful → Midway (Grand Prismatic)			0h15	8
Midway → Madison Campground	15:30	15:55	0h25	16

Before you leave Fishing Bridge: fill the fresh-water tank and use the dump station (Madison has no hook-ups).

West Thumb Geyser Basin — colourful hot springs right on the lakeshore; a quick warm-up boardwalk.

Old Faithful & Upper Geyser Basin — check the predicted eruption time, walk the boardwalks (Castle, Grand, Morning Glory Pool) and step inside the historic Old Faithful Inn. Lunch here.

Midway Geyser Basin — Grand Prismatic Spring, the largest hot spring in the US (Overlook open; check the NPS app for trail closures). A dip on Firehole Canyon Drive on the way is a fun extra.

~16:00 set up at Madison — a lovely change of scene on the Madison River; bison in the meadows, elk at dusk. Dry camping (generator 8 AM–8 PM; nights are cool at 6,800 ft so no overnight AC needed; no showers — you showered at Fishing Bridge).

Fuel: Fill at the Old Faithful station if low — no fuel at Madison Campground itself.

Overnight: Madison Campground (dry camping), +1 307-344-7311

Day 4 — Sun 12 July: Madison → Cody — Canyon & the Rodeo

Driving ~3h25 / ~125 mi — the canyon is right on your way out

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Madison → Canyon (via Norris)	08:00	09:00	1h00	26
Canyon → Fishing Bridge (via Hayden Valley)	10:45	11:30	0h45	27
Fishing Bridge → East Entrance → Cody	11:45	13:50	1h40	79

Morning: the **Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone** — Artist Point and the Lower Falls (an optional Norris Geyser Basin stop en route from Madison).

Late morning: roll south through **Hayden Valley** for wildlife (bison, elk, often grizzly or wolf at distance — stay 100 yds back), past Fishing Bridge and out the East Entrance down the gorgeous Wapiti Valley.

~**14:00 Cody** — check in, then the **Buffalo Bill Center of the West** (firearms, Plains Indian, art, natural history and Buffalo Bill wings; 2–3h, closes 6 PM). Wear the new hats!

19:15 to Stampede Park (gates 7:00). **20:00 Cody Nite Rodeo** — ~2 hours of bronc & bull riding, barrel racing and a kids' calf scramble.

Fuel: Fill up in Cody (last good-value fuel) when you arrive.

Overnight: Parkway RV Campground, Cody, +1 307-527-5927

Day 5 — Mon 13 July: Cody → Casper

Driving ~3h55 / 214 mi — a relaxed half-day

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Cody → Thermopolis	09:30	11:10	1h40	84
Thermopolis → Casper	12:30	14:45	2h15	130

Easy morning in Cody — finish the Buffalo Bill Center, or browse Sheridan Ave for more Western bits.

11:10 Thermopolis — a second soak at Hot Springs State Park and lunch, if you fancy it.

~**14:45 Casper** — arrive mid-afternoon with time for the KOA pool and an easy evening before the last stretch.

Fuel: Fill in Cody, again in Casper.

Overnight: Casper KOA Journey (Bar Nunn), +1 307-577-1664

Day 6 — Tue 14 July: Casper → Fort Collins (early finish!)

Driving ~3h30 / 230 mi — on the lake by early afternoon

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Casper → Fort Collins (I-25 S)	09:00	12:45	3h30	230

09:00 An unhurried start; drive south on I-25 into Colorado.

~12:45 Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA — check in early and make the most of it: paddle boats and fishing on the lake, mini-golf, the pool and the jumping pillow.

Evening: Old Town Fort Collins (the model for Disney's Main Street USA) and the breweries for a relaxed last dinner.

Fuel: Top off near Fort Collins so tomorrow morning is just a quick fill to full.

Overnight: Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA, +1 970-484-9880 (on the lake)

Day 7 — Wed 15 July: Drop the RV → fly home

Driving ~1h00 / 50 mi

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Fort Collins → Road Bear branch	07:30	08:30	1h00	50

07:30 Depart; top the tank to FULL near the branch (return full — stations on Brighton Blvd / near I-270).

08:30 arrive 6586 Brighton Blvd. Drop-off window 8:00–10:30 AM. Your booking includes **Drop & Go** (Platinum Plus) — no tank-dumping or final clean, just hand it back (~30–45 min).

~09:30 transfer to DEN (~30 min). Be airside by ~12:00 for the **14:05** flight to Orlando.

Fuel: Return the tank FULL to avoid the refuel fee.

Overnight: Drop-off — Road Bear, Commerce City

Fuel, supplies & numbers

- **The rig:** Ford E-450 Class C — ~8–10 mpg, ~55-gallon tank (≈ 450–500 mi range, less on grades/AC). Refuel near the half-tank mark.
- **Fuel towns:** Wheatland/Douglas, Casper, Thermopolis, **Cody (always before the park)**, plus in-park stations at Fishing Bridge, Canyon, Old Faithful and Grant.
- **Rough fuel cost:** $\sim 1,280 \text{ mi} \div 9 \text{ mpg} \approx 142 \text{ gal} \times \sim \$3.60 \approx \text{\$510}$ for the week.
- **Water & tanks:** full hook-ups at Fishing Bridge (Fri) — dump and fill the fresh tank there before Saturday's move to Madison, which is one dry-camp night (generator + holding tanks).

Item	Estimate
Park entry	\$35/vehicle (7-day) or \$250 non-resident annual pass
Fishing Bridge RV × 1	~\$94 + tax
Madison × 1	~\$38 + tax
Casper × 2, Cody × 1, Fort Collins × 1	~\$45–75/night

Cody Nite Rodeo × 4 (Sun 12)	~\$25–79/seat
Fuel (week)	~\$510
Road Bear balance at pickup	\$4,085.03 (\$300 deposit already paid)

The drive home, mileage & practical notes

- **Why the way home is easy now:** instead of one 444-mile Cody→Fort Collins marathon, the rodeo is on **Sunday** night, you overnight in **Casper** on Monday, and Tuesday is a short ~230-mile run — so you reach the Fort Collins lake KOA by early afternoon with the whole day to enjoy it.
- **Two bases:** Fishing Bridge (Lake/east, full hook-ups) on Friday, then Madison (riverside/west, in geyser country) on Saturday. Madison is dry camping — no power/water/sewer and no showers — so dump and fill water and shower at Fishing Bridge first, and run the generator 8 AM–8 PM (cool nights mean no overnight AC needed). Book Madison the moment you can; it sells out first.
- **Mileage:** ~1,280 mi vs the 1,400 included; over that, Road Bear charges ~\$0.45/mile + tax. A Lamar Valley wildlife run (~80 mi round trip) is what would tip you over — you've a bit more headroom on this version.
- **Bears & food:** store food/scented items inside, carry bear spray on walks, keep your distance from wildlife.
- **Signal:** poor-to-none across the park — download offline Google Maps and the NPS app, and keep this itinerary saved or printed.
- **Day-of entry:** Yellowstone needs no timed-entry reservation — just your pass — but check nps.gov/yell road & closure alerts the morning you go in.

Web links — tap any name

Campgrounds	Stops & sights
Casper KOA Journey	Road Bear RV (depot)
Fishing Bridge RV Park	Lou Taubert Ranch Outfitters
Madison Campground	Hot Springs State Park, Thermopolis
Parkway RV Campground, Cody	Buffalo Bill Center of the West
Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA	Cody Nite Rodeo (tickets)
Yellowstone NP Lodges (camp res.)	Yellowstone NP — geysers / Old Faithful
Walmart Supercenter (big shop)	Yellowstone National Park (official)

Cody Nite Rodeo tickets: codystampederoodeo.com · Yellowstone campground reservations (2026): Yellowstone National Park Lodges, +1 307-344-7311.

Prepared for Mark Williams · distances and times are approximate · confirm campground, rodeo and store availability when booking.